formal application. All legal hurdles for India joining the SCO were removed at this summit, short of India ratifying the lengthy 28-page document of the SCO group.[16] Hence, India hoped to become a member of SCO at its Ufa Summit in July 2015. Prime Minister Modi attended the Ufa Summit, conveying that membership of SCO would be "a natural extension of India's ties with member countries."[17] Nevertheless, a statement from Moscow prior to the Ufa Summit indicated that accession of India and Pakistan to the SCO was still being examined. It was clear there was a new hitch.[18]

With new attempts to join the SCO in 2016, membership once again proved elusive. After India agreed to sign the base document called the "Memorandum of Obligations" at the 2016 Tashkent Summit, SCO had given a go-ahead for initiating the final process of India's accession to the SCO.[19] Having signed the "Memorandum of Obligations," India also had to sign over 30 mandatory conventions and draft documents of the SCO over a period of time. These documents constituted various obligations already undertaken by existing member states under the SCO framework. The caveat here was possibly the clause of "good neighbourhood" behaviour that India and Pakistan must agree to before acceding to the SCO. India and Pakistan have to adhere to the SCO's expectations, and it appears that the SCO is demanding the equivalent of a "peace treaty" between the two neighbouring countries. As of 2016, the status for India was still that of an "acceding member" and not a full member.[20] Russian officials revealed in June 2016 that the Tashkent Summit would discuss "possible accession" of India (and Pakistan) in 2017, when SCO also planned to admit Iran as a full member.

The insistence on paperwork and bureaucratic processes might have contributed to India's delayed accession, but it appeared to be merely a pretext for China to delay India's